Fiscal Year:	FY 2026	**Task Last Updated:**	FY 06/15/2026
PI Name:	Narayanan, Ranga Ph.D.		
Project Title:	A Novel Way to Measure Interfacial Tension Using the Electrostatic Levitation Furnace (ELF)		
Division Name:	Physical Sciences		
Program/Discipline:			
Program/Discipline--Element/Subdiscipline:	MATERIALS SCIENCE--Materials science		
Joint Agency Name:		**TechPort:**	No
Human Research Program Elements:	None		
Human Research Program Risks:	None		
Space Biology Element:	None		
Space Biology Cross-Element Discipline:	None		
Space Biology Special Category:	None		
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Zip Code:	32611	**Congressional District:**	3
Comments:			
Project Type:	Flight,Ground	**Solicitation / Funding Source:**	2015 NNH15ZTT002N MaterialsLab Open Science Campaigns for Experiments on the International Space Station
Start Date:	05/22/2017	**End Date:**	08/31/2026
No. of Post Docs:	0	**No. of PhD Degrees:**	1
No. of PhD Candidates:	3	**No. of Master' Degrees:**	
No. of Master's Candidates:		**No. of Bachelor's Degrees:**	
No. of Bachelor's Candidates:	2	**Monitoring Center:**	NASA MSFC
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Flight Program:			
Flight Assignment:	NOTE: End date changed to 08/31/2026 per the PI (Ed., 3/30/26) NOTE: End date changed to 08/31/2025 per M. Sansoucie/MSFC (Ed., 4/23/25) NOTE: End date changed to 08/31/2024 per NSSC information (Ed., 6/26/23)		
Key Personnel Changes/Previous PI:			
COI Name (Institution):			
Grant/Contract No.:	NNX17AL27G		
Performance Goal No.:			
Performance Goal Text:			

Task Description:	A novel method using an Electrostatic Levitator (EL) is proposed to determine the surface tension of liquid/gas systems. This key thermophysical property is key to predicting optimum conditions for additive manufacturing, materials processing, and welding operations in space and on ground. The novel method for measurement of surface tension proposed involves the use of electrostatically forced Faraday instability. In this method, an oscillatory electrostatic forcing is applied to a liquid system, resulting in sudden pattern formation at the interface, i.e., an instability is caused. The "instability" is a result of resonance between the imposed forcing frequency and the natural frequency of the system. The critical amplitude and mode shapes are predictable from theory and compared with experiments. The measurement of surface tension directly aligns with the goals of the Thermophysical Property Measurement emphasis of the current NRA (NASA Research Announcement). Faraday experiments by this team using mechanical forcing have shown excellent agreement between theory and experimental results. However, in the case of mechanical forcing, the force of gravity overwhelms the effects of surface tension on the system stability and therefore it is almost impossible to determine this property with accuracy. Electrostatic forcing counters gravity, allowing the effects of surface tension to play a significant role in the ultimate determination of the system stability. Accordingly, experimentally mapped stability curves can be fit accurately with theoretical curves, allowing for the determination of the surface tension with great accuracy. The proposing team has successfully used electrostatic forcing in ground equipment to show that Faraday waves can be obtained as per theoretical predictions. The current state of the art uses an open container geometry to hold the liquid. However, a levitated sphere may also be used, and our proposal uses this containerless method. We therefore propose experiments with an important novel aspect. We propose to use ground-based facilities at JAXA (Japan Aerospace Exploration Agency) and NASA Marshall Space Flight Center (MSFC) to obtain tension for liquids using electrostatic Faraday forcing in using spherical drops by oscillating the drop over a large range of frequencies until the drop resonates with different modal patterns. The surface tension obtained from resonance at one modal patterns will be verified from deduced surface tension from another modal patterns. This will provide a self-consistent bench mark for determining surface tension. In summary, the research allows an alternate new method, viz., Faraday instability, for the determination of surface tension. Using electrostatic forcing instability will permit an independent confirmation of measurements obtained by the single-pulse oscillating-drop technique where decay rates are measured and related to surface tension and viscosity. The proposed method will also provide a slef consistent bench mark. Ground-based research using the electrostatic levitator available at the NASA MSFC and JAXA, and space experiments on ELF in the International Space Station (ISS) will provide accurate data. In addition to being an alternative method for surface tension measurement, the proposed technique also has versatility as a potential means in measuring surface tension for high viscosity materials and two-liquid interfacial tension on ground as well as in space. The proposing team has recently collaborated successfully with JAXA and has conducted experiments to study the feasibility of electrostatic Faraday instability. These results form the basis for the current proposal.
Rationale for HRP Directed Research:	
Research Impact/Earth Benefits:	Accurate surface tension values lead to transformative impact with space and Earth benefits such as a) Additive manufacturing of metals, where knowledge of surface tension is pivotal for predictive modeling to avoid rippling during solidification and possible wrinkling and shrinkage.. Human Exploration: Technology Area (TA) TA7.2.3.5: Welding, TA12.1.2: Computationally-Designed Materials, TA12.4.2.5: Additive Manufacturing. b) Space enabling operations. One example is joining operations such as soldering, where the surface plays an important role in the structure and stability of the weld. Accurate values for the surface tension will enhance the safety and effectiveness of this type of operation in space where the microstructures formed are different than those on Earth where gravity is present. c) Semiconductor crystal growth, where the interfacial tension between a liquid melt and liquid encapsulant plays a large role in determining conditions where convection is present.
Task Progress:	We report a new method of analysis to measure the surface tension of high melt-temperature liquid metals using levitation in microgravity. The method, which leads to a self-consistent benchmarking technique to determine surface tension, requires forced oscillations of a levitated drop until the drop responds by deforming at a target mode, say the first fundamental mode of the natural frequency of the drop. Decomposition of the drop shape into Legendre modes, followed by time-domain analysis, reveals that the response to a target-mode forcing is composed of multiple modes that oscillate at frequencies, commensurate with the natural frequencies of those modes. We refer to the multiple modes that emanate from the target mode forcing as subordinate or ancillary modes. This then means that multiple modal shapes constituting the deforming drop's response co-exist. It is found that the ratios of the experimentally determined ancillary modal frequencies correlate well with the theoretical ratios predicted by the Rayleigh formula, thereby providing a self-consistent benchmark method for surface tension determination for any given sample, regardless of its composition. Validation of this method has been performed using experiments on the Electrostatic Levitation Furnace (ELF) in the KIBO module aboard the International Space Station (ISS), demonstrating accuracy and precision.
Bibliography Type:	Description: (Last Updated: 06/17/2026)
Articles in Peer-reviewed Journals	Brosius N, Zoueshtiagh F, Narayanan R. "Enhancement of heat transfer using Faraday instability." Journal of Fluid Mechanics. 2025 Aug;1016:A35. https//doi:10.1017/jfm.2025.1041 , Aug-2025
Articles in Peer-reviewed Journals	Corbin T, Livesay J, Ishikawa T, Koyama C, SanSoucie M, Phillips B, Narayanan R. "RIIST, resonance induced instability for surface tension measurement, a new technique with experiments in microgravity." npj Microgravity. 2026 Apr 6. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41526-026-00585-1 , Apr-2026
Articles in Peer-reviewed Journals	Narayanan R. "Knowing thermo-physical properties for space manufacturing." SPACE. 2026 Apr 29;2(1):1-5. https://doi.org/10.32473/space.2.1.142125 , Apr-2026

Patents	Patent application filed [UFPT19787US001] (222112-8530 Pending May-2026 Corbin T, Livesay J, Narayanan R. "Self-Consistent Oscillations in Patterned Excitation for Surface-Tension (SCOPES)."
Significant Media Coverage	Smith AW. (Narayanan R interview). "Good vibrations: Transforming cooling and 3D printing in space. Dr. Narayanan interviewed for ISS National Laboratory magazine." Upward Magazine, published by CASIS, November 19, 2025., Nov-2025